

Andean condor

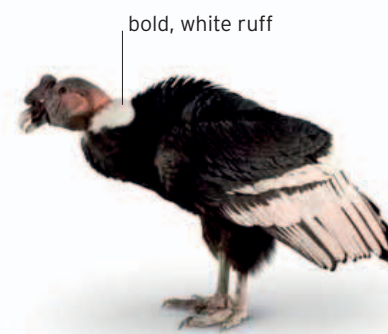
Vultur gryphus

The Andean condor has the largest wing area of any bird, and its wingspan is more than 10 ft (3 m). Condors rely entirely on constant winds and rising thermal air currents to fly. They can glide great distances using gravity alone—energetic flapping is not an option for such a heavy bird. Fortunately, perpetual winds allow condors to search beaches, plateaus, and valleys, confident they can regain height easily.

Condors feed on carrion, using their strong bills to tear the hides and flesh. Unlike eagles and hawks, the condors' long legs are used simply for standing, not for killing prey. In the past, Andean condors mainly fed on vicuñas, guanacos, and seals, but nowadays they more often eat dead domestic livestock. Although no longer common, in their core range flocks of 30 or 40 condors still gather around large carcasses.

On the wane

Andean condors breed only once every two years and miss a year if food is short. The whole reproduction cycle is long and slow: females lay just one egg, which hatches after 56 to 58 days, and then it is six months before the chick can fly. Chicks rely on their parents for several months more. Young birds do not breed for six years, often more. Condors balance this low “output” with very low natural mortality—they can live for 70 years—but whole populations are extremely vulnerable to human persecution. They are simply unable to make up lost numbers quickly, if at all.



bold, white ruff



- ↔ 3–4 ft (1–1.3 m)
- ⚖ 24–33 lb (11–15 kg)
- ⊗ Near threatened
- ☠ Dead mammals
- 🏠



NW. to SW.
South
America

△ COMMUNAL ROOSTING

Groups of condors roost in remote caves and on sheltered ledges. In the morning, they leave their perch and rise effortlessly on thermal currents.

